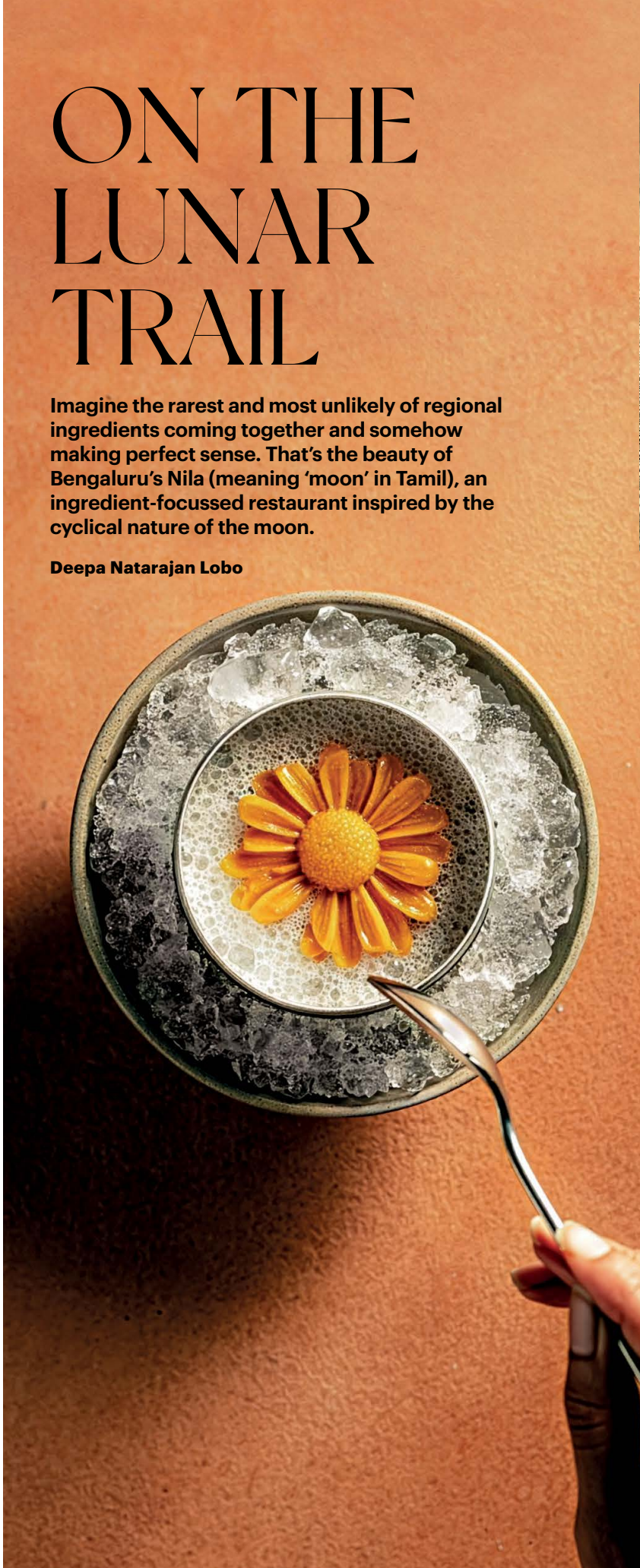
FINE LIVING

RESTAURANT

ON THE LUNAR TRAIL

Imagine the rarest and most unlikely of regional ingredients coming together and somehow making perfect sense. That's the beauty of Bengaluru's Nila (meaning 'moon' in Tamil), an ingredient-focussed restaurant inspired by the cyclical nature of the moon.

Deepa Natarajan Lobo



Helmed by Chef Rahul Sharma, this degustation restaurant that started in January was imagined as a journey rather than a destination—one that draws you in with bold flavours that surprise at every turn. The 12-course tasting menu shifts every three months, currently zeroing in on Nagaland from India's Northeast, unfolding at its own leisurely pace. Many of these courses are meant to be eaten with hands, keeping the sojourn simple, local and memorable.

The open kitchen sits right in the middle and visitors are encouraged to walk around between courses and soak in the entire culinary craftsmanship. The experience kicks off gently in Nila's 'living room' with rhododendron tea and crunchy banana chips—a simple, spot-on duo that sets a cosy tone. The meal then gets going with each course expertly explained by the chef and team, beginning with a triangular black rice momo wrapped in tapioca leaf, spiked with chili and mellowed out by a tangy gondhoraj dressing. This is followed by a tree tomato custard— tomato jelly in the shape of a flower sitting pretty on a savoury, garlicky custard. This is served chilled on a bed of ice and hits the sweet spot. The black soya bean tart served on a ragi biscuit, is a perfect one-bite mix of crunch and softness.

The yam milk and lima beans soup with crispy garlic bits and a soft onion petal is comfort in a mug served with a pair of chewy savoury mochi waffles. The pickled persimmon kebabs served on skewers layered with a coconut malai or smoked pork follows next.